

Chrome OS to come soon

Google has announced that it expects the first Chrome OS netbooks to be launched between September and November this year

IMMINENT TECHNOLOGIES

Upcoming Technologies That Are All Set To Change Our Lives

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Arthur C. Clarke, the incomparable sci-fi novelist, futurist and inventor, believed that a sufficiently advanced technology often seems like magic to us. One of the few accurate predictors of technologies of the future, Clarke would have been pleased to find that all

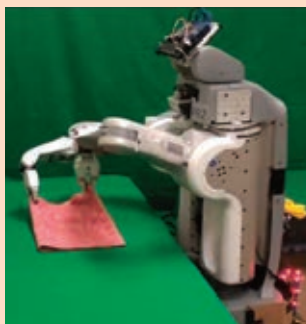
around the world, scientists are steadily working towards the attainment of technologies that even magicians would have a hard time pulling out of their hats. Besides, none of these are even close to the typical apocalyptic doomsday scenarios of Hollywood sci-fi projections. Here's a quick look at scientific innovations that are likely to reach culmination really soon and change our lives for the better.



Sci-fi flicks tend to paint bleak pictures of future technology

Robo Sapiens

Robotic assistants have been around for some time, but none of them have proved to be viable alternatives to human helpers. All that is set to change. The rapid commercialisation of robotic technology and large amounts of private funding over the last two decades (cases in point are Honda's ASIMO and Sony's AIBO) has taken the field ahead by a quantum jump. Robots are soon going to be an indispensable part of your home.



Doing more than just the laundry

'Soft' Skills

Another interesting robotic innovation is a robot that folds towels. Assistant Professor Pieter Aibeel of UC Berkeley and Jeremy Martin-Shepard have, with the help of the robotics company Willow Garage, developed a robot that folds piles of towels of different parameters with as much efficiency as any homemaker. Finally, computer 'sight' capabilities have been taken to a point where robots can effectively deal with deformable objects too. While this is at the prototype stage, it signifies an important advancement in robotic programming and one major step into our homes.



Robots that clean up for you

Mint

Pasadena based Evolution Robotics Inc. and Yves Behar, the industrial designer, have teamed up to create a little robotic appliance called 'Mint' that makes your vacuum cleaner look like a horse carriage. This is all set to give other home gadgets such as iRobot's Dirt Dog competition. Mint dusts and mops hard surface floors using branded cleaning materials and uses a special movement to clean the cracks and crannies that typically accumulate dust. What makes it unique is that it uses a navigation technology called North-Star (created by Evolution too) that enables it to map a room, plan the cleaning path and avoid patches that have been already cleaned. Sensors allow Mint to differentiate between types of floors (rough or slippery) and it never gets caught in a rug. While it should be launched in the US anytime soon, consumers all around the world would be able to leave the cleaning to somebody - or something - else by the end of 2011.